The Declaration of Independence (1776)

It was Richard Lee who proposed that the colonies should be independent states. A draft committee was formed to draft the declaration of independence whose members included Thomas Jefferson, Benjamin Franklin, and John Adams.

The British army was led by William Howe while the American forces were led by George Washington. Though in the initial phases Howe made a few successful attempts by defeating Washington at Brooklyn, New York and New Jersey, Washington, through his planned military tactics inflicted defeat on the British army. In 1777, at the Battle of Saratoga, the British General Burgoyne was forced to surrender. Finally, the British forces surrendered to the American forces in 1781 at York Town. With this victory the northern colonies became free. However, Howe retained New York almost till the end of the war.



American war of independence

Solidarity of European Powers with Colonists

During the American war of independence, the European powers that were not on friendly terms with the British decided to support the American colonies. The countries in Northern Europe including Prussia, Sweden and Denmark formed the 'Armed neutrality' against Great Britain. Britain was in turmoil as it had to face hostility from its enemies as well as neutral powers.

The French, followed by the Spanish and the Dutch, helped the American colonies in this war of independence. France lent support to the Americans as vengeance against the loss of Canada. The French volunteers who crossed the Atlantic to fight for the colonists returned with ideas of individual liberty which made them intolerant of the restrictions of the Bourbon monarchy.

Thomas (Tom) Paine and *Common Sense*

Thomas Paine, an Englishman, wrote the pamphlet titled *Common Sense* (1776). In this pamphlet Paine sought to provide arguments to justify the demands of the colonists. He picked up libertarian ideas from Hobbes, Locke, Voltaire and Rousseau and presented them in ways the common people could understand. The pamphlet sold over 150,000 copies and had an astounding impact of people.

Many of the wealthy merchants and large landowners remained loyal to the British monarchy and influenced a large section of the population especially in New York and Pennsylvania. The colonists split into two divisions: the Patriots who wanted freedom and the Loyalists who wanted to remain loyal to the British crown. The Loyalists, called Tories, wanted the British to rule as they belonged to the Anglican Church. So a civil war in the midst of the revolution became inevitable.

Treaty of Paris

In 1783, the British Parliament decided that it was pointless to carry on the war. Lord North resigned as Prime Minister. King George lost control over the House of Commons. The new Prime Minister Lord Rockingham started the peace talks. A peace treaty was signed between the Great Britain and America in 1783 at Paris.



George Washington

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